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I'm Mean to my Kids



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By Brian Weilert

I'm mean to my kids. I don't try to be but they just frustrate me to no end. Every day, as a teacher, I have to be nice ALL THE TIME. I solve problems, I act pleasant in the face of flagrant disrespect and when I get home, I'll be damned if my kids are going to act that way! My tolerance is lowering at school as well. Monday, as I was walking through the gym I heard a Junior High student make a funny comment about the way I walked. In fairness to the little maggot this was something I was accustomed to as my "racewalk" style had been mimicked for years. However, I snapped! Walking over to him and whisper yelling, "What did you say?" I gave myself chills. It had a certain Dirty Harry quality to it and I was pleased.

He responded poorly with a, " Don't yell in my face man!" Which of course, I was doing.

In all my maturity I repeated, LOUDER this time. "WHAT DID YOU SAY, BOY?" I thought the "boy" part was a nice touch. His eyes darted from side to side looking at his classmates, desperate to save some pride.

"Man, you are so lucky there are rules against fighting in school," he threatened me. Ma Bell took control of my body as I reached out and touched someone. My hand was a full flexed Kung-Fu vice on the nape of the young boy's neck. I pulled him real close. His eyes were large like the crowning head of a newborn. All cockiness had evaporated. My mouth was inches from his ears; my morning coffee-breath ricocheting off his cheek skin and back up my nose. It stunk. At that moment I was glad.

In a exaggerated breathy Darth Vaderisk voice I responded with, "Those rules are not in place to protect me from you, little man, but to protect you from ME." With that I released the Bavarian Death Grip and race walked to my original destination, a crapper with a door on the stall.

I was nice to my kids that night. I even played a board game. For me this was huge as board games usually fell right behind puzzles and driving thermometers under my skin and then snapping the glass on my short list of things to do on my free time.

But I was on to something.

On Tuesday I decided to keep a special eye out for any thing I would not let my own children get away with. I didn't have to wait long. During my 1st hour speech class I was bouncing around the room giving a riveting lecture on how one's self concept is developed. I was deep into the subject of how distorted feedback, information that person "A" says to person "B" could damage

person "B's"image of himself. I was using an example of how an abusive parents might tell their own children that they are worthless and the children would accept this as the truth, forever being harmed. When I noticed at the far corner of the room, which if I had Glaucoma would have entirely eluded me, a rapid flurry of motion. I whipped around in time to see my next victim, er...student turned to a fellow classmate who sat behind her and swore I caught the remaining motion of what was left of a slap to the top of the head. I felt this might be a great moment to put my lecture into a more practical "real world" setting. I am always looking for new teaching strategies which will benefit kids. It's all about the kids. "What the on God's green earth are you doing?" I screamed. The young girl quickly faced the front looking very much like a person who was caught thumping a classmate on top of the head. It was at this point I began my *hands-on* self concept lesson. "Are you that stupid? I am almost sickened at the childish display of your ignorant adolescent antics. Did your mother drop you at birth reaching for her crack pipe? Do you live under power lines? You have to be the most retarded, disgusting, rude lump of garbage that I have ever had the burden of trying to teach!" She ran from the room in a fit of tears. I turned to the class and asked if there were any questions. There were not

That night I took my family out to eat and a movie. We even ran by the Putt Putt course for a quick 18. My children's laughter warmed my heart.

Wednesday, as luck would have it, during my lunch I witnessed a micro-food fight as I caught a glare from a butter coated bun somersaulting in the air only to land short of its target with a thump on the floor. A table filled with giggles narrowed the culprit down to five. Much to my delight three of the worms were students I had heard cussing in the hall last week. I had done nothing about it. But now..... "OK which one of you little bastards threw the bun?"

One small meek hand raised above the plain of down cast heads. "I did."

"Well get you bun throwing ass over there and pick it up!" I was sure my vulgar display of language had taught them the important lesson of not using profanity.

My family camped in the back yard that night, hadn't done if for years. We roasted marshmallows, wienies, told ghost stories and went to sleep under the light of the moon. I thought, how truly blessed I was to have such great kids.

Thursday went along fine until the last hour of the day. I had heard whispers in the hall along the lines of, "The dude's crazy." I smiled inside. One student, who had been ill since Monday was apparently unaware of my new found *therapy* for better family relations. She slipped up during English class. I had just handed back papers. When this young lady saw her grade she rolled her eyes. I should point out that she always wanted to be a writer and in her mind I was a child grading the works of Shelly with a crayon. This time her eye roll was accompanied with a, "Can I speak with you at your desk?" Once there, she used this time to point out how every red mark upon her paper was really a badge of shame for me, magnifying my ignorance. Each correction from ME carried with it a snotty 5 minute retort from HER. I let her go until about the 4th red pen stroke, just below the long-time-due fragmented thesis. At this time I reached out and plucked the paper from her boney hands, rolled it into a make-shift telescope and brought it to my eye, pirate style. I panned about until I had her eyes looking down the tube at my eye.

"Why, what is this I scope?" I calmly stated as if I were talking to a four year old. "Why, I spy an egotistical, disrespectful, disruptive bitch." I couldn't have been more polite as the words drained from my mouth.

This may sound harsh but the refrain I showed was really quite incredible. I wanted to gut her with the *Old Timer* pocket knife I had in my center drawer. I unrolled the paper, and with big theatrical waves of my arms, tore the drivel into eight equal pieces. I then handed the stack, which resembled a poorly constructed deck of cards, back to the fine young lady. There was a very awkward pause as she stared in disbelief at the huge tight lipped smiled stretched across my face. Like a zombie, she returned to her seat and remained silent until the bell.

I hurried home that day to fire up the grill. By the time my wife came home the steaks were ready. My two boys took turns trying to catch the football as I threw to them on the trampoline. I would time it to where they were at the maximum peak when the catch was made. I invented the game three years ago, the first day we purchased it. I had not played since. I was never so alive, so loved as I was that Thursday night.

On Friday, I had just turned the key to my classroom when I was summoned to the office via the intercom. I dumped my briefcase onto my desk headed down the hall. As I rounded the corner, I could see though the windows, which lined each side of the principal's office, the parents of each of the students I had encountered during the week. The principal's eyes caught mine and she nodded for me to enter. I crossed the threshold and issued a general, "Hi", to the group of five adults; three single mothers and a complete parental set. With a sweeping hand, I was nonverbally instructed to sit opposite the lynch squad. I could go into great detail as to what was said at that meeting but to do so is not necessary. The message that was conveyed, does however bear some explanation. Over the next twenty-five minutes my hand was shook by each of the five parents, twice by the mother of the young budding author. Each, in their own way, thanked me for being honest with their children and for disciplining inappropriate behavior. They informed me that they wished more teachers would take such an aggressive approach to stopping unacceptable actions. I felt as though I should call *Ripley's*. In some quirk of the universe these parents had found each other and come together to support a teacher. I am not positive, but I am 99.27% sure this had never happened before. Over the next few weeks, my reputation spread like an airborne virus. Around me students worked hard, were well behaved and respectful. My job became peaceful, serene. As a result I became the teacher I always knew I could be.

That Friday night my family ate a meal at the dining table for the first time in months. The t.v. was off. I found that my oldest son had just finished building a race car out of a mouse trap for his science class. My younger son earned a free pizza coupon for reading more books than anyone else in his 2nd grade class. My wife shared with me that she had never been happier than this past week. I kept my *therapy* secret to myself. After dinner we sat down, all of us, and put together a puzzle. I realized, at that moment, that I had become the father and husband I always knew I could be.

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